

Does more RO mean recovery?

Reverse-osmosis supply, groundwater status and the Għar Lapsi tender

THE CLAIM

“70.7% ... from the four Reverse Osmosis plants”

Water Services Corporation, Annual Report 2025

WSC production, 2022–2025 · Plant B tender, August 2026

A lower WSC groundwater share is not proof of aquifer recovery.

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

*WSC reliance fell;
aquifers last assessed as poor.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

70.7%

WSC production from RO

In 2025, up from 64.3% in 2022.

–8.95%

WSC groundwater production

Change from 2022 to 2025; not total national abstraction.

2 aquifers

poor quantitative status

The latest River Basin Management Plan says Malta and Gozo's main aquifers are over-abtracted; Malta's EU reporting lists four.

12 of 15

above nitrate standard

The plan names three exceptions; nitrate is not the only cause of poor chemical status.

30,000 m³/day

planned Għar Lapsi Plant B

Tendered in August 2026; not commissioned or measured output.

FAIR TO SAY

RO supplied more of WSC's potable production and its groundwater component fell. The latest national aquifer assessment still reports poor status; a tender does not establish recovery.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

- ☐ Publish abstraction and recharge by groundwater body and user sector.
- ☐ Monitor water levels, salinity and nitrate on a comparable basis.
- ☐ Reconcile WSC's 11.4% narrative with its 11.86% chart-derived decline.
- ☐ Report Plant B's actual output and its effect on groundwater production.